

LETTER CONCERNING THE ACCORD OF MOURNTHRONE

To the Custodian of the Ashen Vanguard's war-records,

I set down what may safely be read, and what must be read between the soot-black lines.

The Accord of Mournthrone began in 297 AS. It ended in 301 AS, with the Ashen Vanguard named victor. Those are the words fit for proclamations, seal-stamped ledgers, and the mouths of heralds. I have copied them myself, though the ink seemed reluctant to remain upon the page.

Yet the Accord has never looked like a victory to those who stood beneath its shadow. Its mark is a broken accord overshadowed by Mournthrone and the Ashen Vanguard: fractured lines, dark stone, and a banner hanging where no wind could properly lift it. The image tells more truth than the triumphal verses. It shows not a wound closed, but a door barred with rotten timber.

They say the terms failed. They say pride outlived reason. They say the defeated were too stubborn to yield and the victors too righteous to relent. Such sayings are convenient, and convenience is the favored cloak of power.

The hidden truth is this: the losing commander was bribed to withdraw.

I did not learn this from a tavern mouth or a frightened camp follower. I learned it from the silence that followed the withdrawal, from the missing certainty in every account, and from the way certain hands trembled whenever the Accord was praised as cleanly won. Still, I will not swear that truth is a noble thing. It may merely be another blade, kept sheathed until its owner finds a throat worth opening.

For the Accord's collapse unleashed a decade of guerrilla reprisals. Let no clerk soften that phrase. A decade is long enough for vengeance to become inheritance, for children to learn the old grievances before they learn the old prayers, and for every road to remember the tread of men who came by night. The victory was named; the peace was not.

Thus the Accord of Mournthrone endures as a sullen prelude to

reprisal. Its banners may be folded, its seals broken, its account entered under the Ashen Vanguard's triumph, but the matter is not settled in any heart that witnessed it. Those who call it finished are either ignorant, bought, or waiting.

Keep this letter beneath the harmless records. Burn it if questioned. Should the seal be found broken, deny that you ever saw my hand.

In ash and caution, A Faithful Clerk